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SPRING 2025

Homeschooling *and beyond*

Oxtail Stew

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**A Story of
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Maths vs Maths Literacy

What's Best for Your Teen?

**How extra lessons fill
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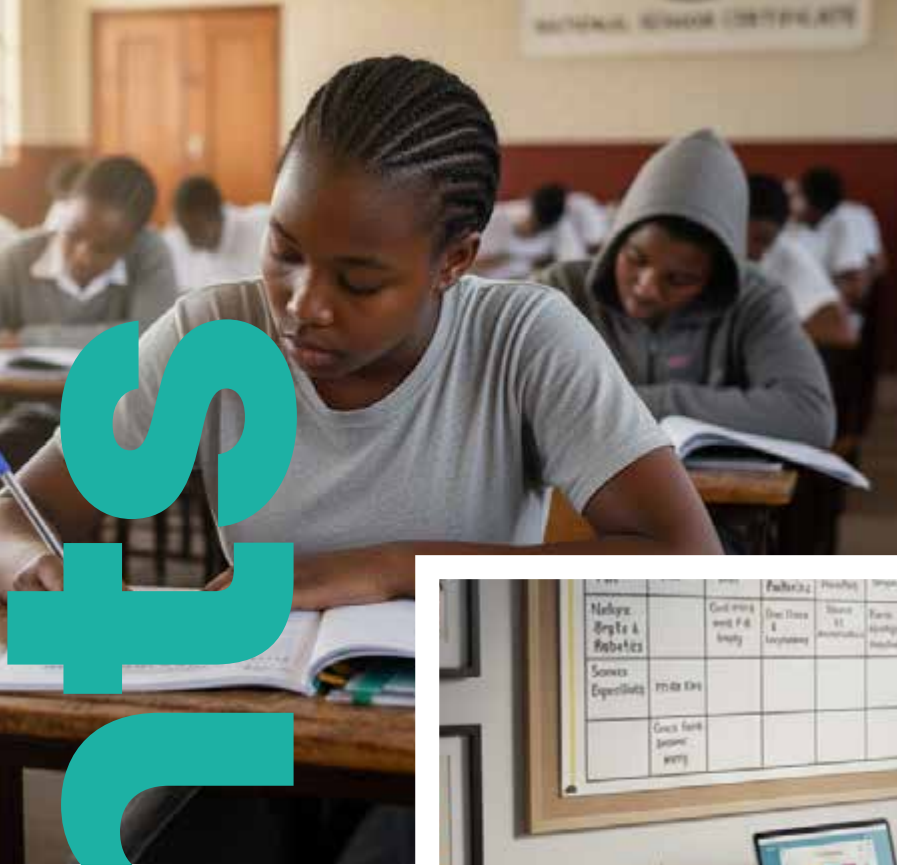
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At Classical Conversations, we believe homeschooling is more than academics, it's about shaping hearts, minds, and character for a lifetime of learning. Rooted in the classical model, our communities equip parents and encourage children to become curious thinkers, clear communicators, and compassionate leaders.

When you join us, you're not walking this journey alone. With Christ at the center, you'll find supportive families, weekly community days that inspire, and resources that guide you step by step. Together, we cultivate wisdom, nurture curiosity, and build strong foundations for faith and learning that last a lifetime.



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Hello everyone,

As a modern online publisher, AI is a hot topic. Many in our industry fear for their jobs. From writers to editors and photographers to designers, publishing professionals feel like they're at risk after years of studying and working.

Just like typing pools became redundant with the advent of the personal computer and word processors, or the horseshoe fitter lost his job to the motor car, people have to reinvent themselves to adapt to the new world.

The same applies now. As AI makes certain functions easier, people need to reskill for this new era.

So is this the time for us to begin introducing these skills into our education system? Ashley Bruyns, Head of Engineering at Altron Systems Integration, explains why AI needs to be integrated into our education curriculum to skill our kids for this new world.

In a packed issue, we also look at how homeschooling families deal with neurodivergence. Cherise Botha, a South African mother of three boys shares how her family navigated her son Leo's dual diagnoses of acute lymphoblastic leukaemia and autism spectrum disorder. Our resident cognitive development specialist, Dalena van der Westhuizen also provides a parent's guide to ADHD.

We're also at that time in the year when our matriculant children face anxiety and fear over what happens next. Vimala Ariyan, the CEO of Star Schools, provides a wonderful guide on how to support your child on how to deal with life after matric.

Read on for so much more to help you in your parenting, educational and developmental homeschooling journey.

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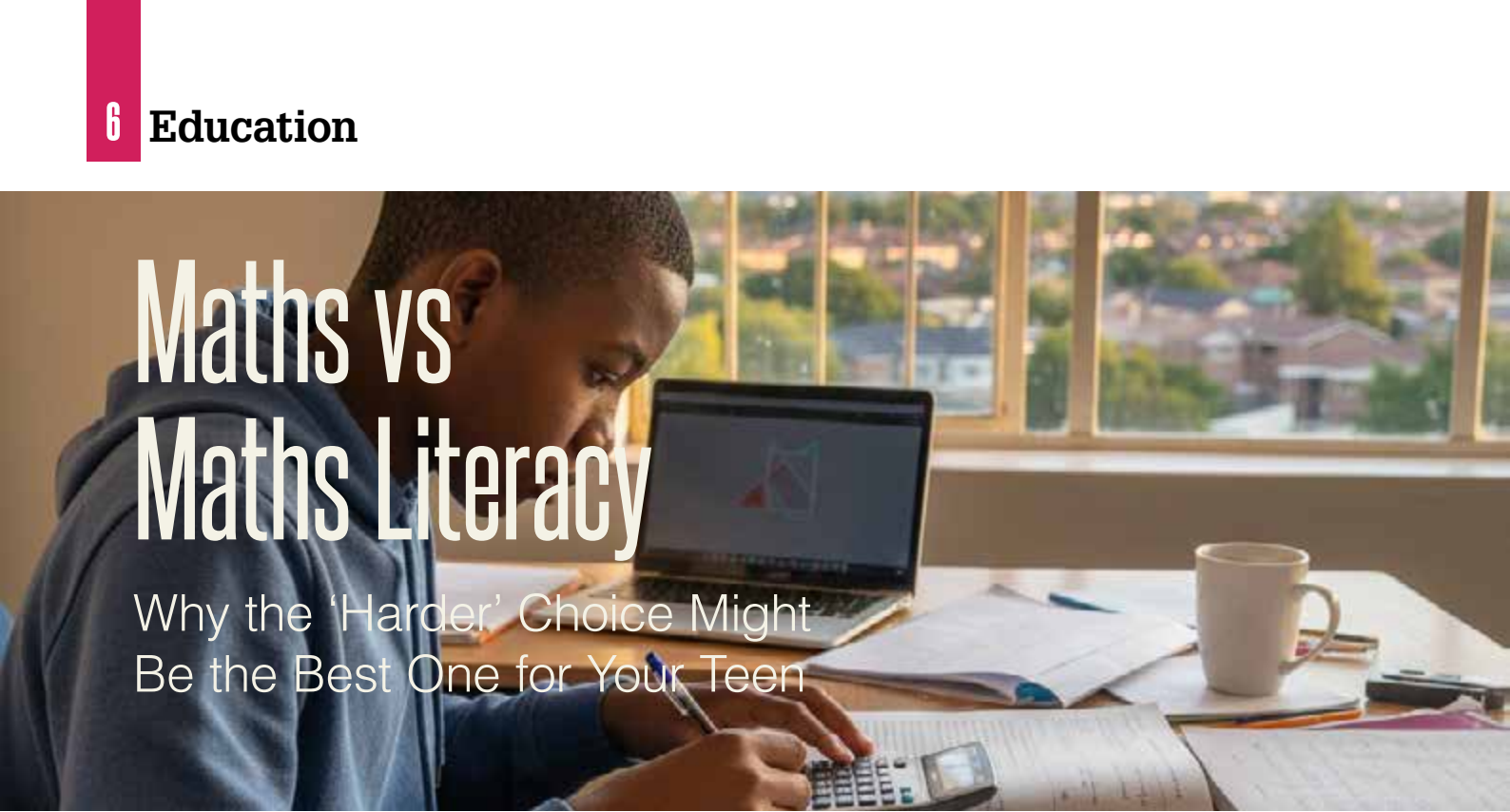
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Maths vs Maths Literacy

Why the 'Harder' Choice Might Be the Best One for Your Teen

The choice between maths and maths literacy has lifelong consequences. Philip Hlatshwayo from the IIE explains why sticking with pure maths, despite its challenges, is a powerful investment in your child's future, building resilience, critical thinking, and keeping career doors wide open.

As a homeschooling parent in South Africa, you guide your child through many critical milestones. Few are as significant as the subject choices for grade 10; a decision that shapes their future academic and career paths. At the heart of this decision often lies a tough question: pure maths or maths literacy?

The debate over maths vs maths literacy is a common one. The promise of a less demanding workload and potentially higher marks makes maths literacy an attractive option, especially for a student who finds maths challenging. However, this short-term relief can come at a long-term cost.

Philip Hlatshwayo, an education expert at the Independent Institute of Education, warns, "South African students are increasingly opting for maths literacy without having thought through all the consequences." Before making this pivotal choice, it's essential to understand what is truly at stake.

The Hidden Benefits of Pure Maths

While many see maths as a subject you either "get" or "don't," its value extends far beyond finding the right answer to an equation. Sticking with pure maths, even when it's difficult, develops skills and character traits that are invaluable in any field.

Building Mental Muscle

Pure maths is challenging. It requires patience, persistence, and the willingness to work through a problem even when the solution isn't immediately obvious. "Beyond the technical, sticking with maths during challenging times builds tenacity and resilience," says Hlatshwayo. This process of grappling with complex ideas builds a mental toughness that serves a student well beyond their school years,

teaching them not to give up when faced with a difficult task.

Developing a Problem-Solver's Mindset

One of the most significant benefits of pure maths is the development of critical thinking skills. Hlatshwayo explains that the real lesson isn't just the answer, but "the process it takes for you to arrive at that answer."

This process teaches students to:

- Analyse problems from multiple angles.
- Organise information logically.
- Identify and test different solutions.
- Reason through complex arguments.

"South African students are increasingly opting for maths literacy without having thought through all the consequences."

These are the foundational skills for effective problem-solving in any career and in life.

Career Options with Pure Maths

The most immediate consequence of the maths vs maths literacy decision is access to higher education. Maths literacy is not accepted as a prerequisite for degrees in fields that are quantitatively demanding.

The list of career options with pure maths is extensive and includes:

Science & Engineering: All fields, from medicine and veterinary science to civil engineering and computer science.

Commerce & Finance: Actuarial science, accounting, economics, investment banking, and data analytics.

Technology: Software development, artificial intelligence, and cybersecurity.

Other Fields: Architecture, commercial law, and even psychology often require strong analytical skills and may have

a maths prerequisite at certain universities.

Choosing maths literacy can close these doors before a student has even had a chance to explore their interests fully. The University of Cape Town's Science Faculty, for



example, clearly lists Mathematics as a requirement for all its undergraduate programmes.

How to Support Your Homeschooled Teen

Convincing a struggling teen to stick with pure maths can be a challenge. Your role is not just to teach, but to support and encourage. Here's how you can help:

Find the Right Resources: You don't have to be a maths expert yourself. Utilise excellent online resources like Khan Academy for free tutorials, or consider hiring a tutor who specialises in the CAPS curriculum.

Focus on Understanding, Not Just Marks: Shift the focus from "getting 80%" to "understanding the concept." When a child truly understands the "why" behind a formula, their confidence grows.

Praise the Effort: Acknowledge their hard work and persistence. Celebrate the small victories and the progress they make, not just the final test score. Frame challenges as opportunities for growth.

How have you approached the maths vs maths literacy discussion with your teen? Share your experiences and tips with us. Email editor@digitalafrikan.com

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SCAN ME

WHY AI IN EDUCATION SOUTH AFRICA IS A NECESSARY NEXT STEP

Ashley Bruyns of Altron Systems Integration discusses embracing AI in education in South Africa. He explores the benefits, addresses concerns like the digital divide and critical thinking, and offers insights for homeschooling parents on responsibly integrating AI tools into learning for a future-ready generation.

Artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming our world, and the education sector is no exception. While AI tools offer significant benefits, concerns about their impact on jobs and critical thinking persist. Many parents worry about students taking shortcuts, “copying and pasting” instead of engaging in deep thinking.

However, as Ashley Bruyns, Head of Engineering at Altron Systems Integration, points out, the critical question is: “with these tools available to everyone, how can we embrace, rather than exclude, them from the education system?”. For AI in education South Africa, especially within the flexible framework of homeschooling, responsible adoption is key.

Instead of banning AI tools, the focus should shift to teaching children how to use

them responsibly as powerful educational resources. This mirrors past anxieties about calculators, which were initially viewed with suspicion but are now standard educational aids. “As with calculators, technological

in South Africa is the existing digital divide. Unequal access to technology and internet connectivity can lead to wider disparities in educational outcomes. “The need to close the gap between the haves and have-

As with calculators, technological disruption from AI within the education space is inevitable and has its place, as long as children are taught how it can add value.”

Ashley Bruyns, Head of Engineering, Altron Systems Integration

disruption from AI within the education space is inevitable and has its place, as long as children are taught how it can add value,” Bruyns notes.

The Digital Divide and Information Reliability

A significant hurdle for widespread adoption of AI in education

notes when it comes to technology is well recognised,” the original article states. Initiatives like the SA Connect programme aim to improve broadband access, which is foundational for leveraging AI tools.

Another challenge is the reliability of information provided by AI. “It’s vital to teach the importance



of not taking everything at face value. Verifying sources and fact-checking are imperative when using AI, as well as across all modern communication platforms,” Bruyns stresses. This reinforces the need for strong critical thinking skills.

Responsible AI Use in Your Homeschool

The good news is that many forward-thinking schools and institutions in South Africa are adopting AI as a learning tool, with an emphasis on appropriate use. Homeschooling families can also cultivate this approach:

Educate on AI Basics: Help children understand what AI is, how it works (at a basic level), and its potential biases.

Promote Critical Evaluation:

Teach them to question AI-generated content, cross-reference information with reliable sources, and identify potential inaccuracies. The UNESCO report on AI and education emphasizes the need for “AI literacy” for both educators and learners.

Teach Ethical Use: Discuss plagiarism and the importance of citing sources, even if AI assisted in generating ideas or text. Explain that AI tools should augment their learning, not replace their own thinking and effort.

Focus on Process, Not Just

Output: Encourage students to use AI as a thinking partner – to brainstorm, get different perspectives, or overcome a learning block – rather than just for final answers.

Model Responsible Use:

As parents and educators, demonstrate how you use AI tools thoughtfully and ethically in your own work or learning.

Beyond Copying and Pasting

Concerns about students “copying and pasting” are valid if AI is used without guidance. However, when integrated thoughtfully, AI can enhance learning and critical thinking. Bruyns provides an example: “a student doing programming can prompt ChatGPT to generate small snippets of code.

The student then needs to apply critical thinking and evaluation to complete the code”. “Far from blindly copying what the AI tool provides, they can leverage its expertise and learn more efficiently”.

For homeschooling parents, AI tools can offer numerous benefits

PERSONALISED LEARNING

AI can adapt to individual student learning paces and styles, offering tailored explanations and exercises. Platforms like Khan Academy are already incorporating AI to provide personalised tutoring experiences.

RESEARCH ASSISTANCE

AI can help students find information quickly, summarise complex texts, and even generate bibliographies, freeing up time for deeper analysis.

SKILL DEVELOPMENT

AI tools can assist in learning new languages, improving writing skills through feedback on grammar and style, and practising maths problems.

CREATIVE EXPLORATION

AI can generate ideas for creative writing, art projects, or even music composition, acting as a springboard for a student's own creativity.

SUPPORT FOR DIVERSE LEARNERS

AI-powered text-to-speech, speech-to-text, and translation tools can be invaluable for students with learning differences or those learning in a second language.

How are you considering or already using AI tools for homeschooling? Share your thoughts and experiences with us by emailing editor@digitalafrikan.com.

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From left to right: Karin van Oostrum (Pestalozzi Trust), Minister Siviwe Gwarube, Minister of Basic Education, her official, Christopher Cordeiro (Pestalozzi Trust), Imaad Isaacs (Futures Academy)

Pestalozzi Trust Meets the Minister and Former Chief Justice Zondo

A regular update from the Pestalozzi Trust on legal, policy, and advocacy developments affecting home education in South Africa.

In early August, during the SAELA (South African Education Law Association) Conference (3–6 August), the Pestalozzi Trust was able to briefly meet the Minister of Basic Education and have lengthier engagements with the Minister's staff on the direction of education law reform.

Our discussion centred on the implications of the BELA Act, the need for a child-centred legal framework, and practical safeguards for families learning outside conventional schooling.

At the conference we also interacted with a wide range

of sector stakeholders, such as, the DBE and provincial education department officials, SACE representatives, and other education-rights NGOs. We exchanged views on workable regulation that recognises educational diversity and protects family autonomy.

Quality Education and Community Responsibility

Former Chief Justice Raymond Zondo also addressed the SAELA Conference with a clear message: the constitutional right to basic education must be realised as a right to quality education, and communities have a role in driving improvement. He highlighted education's power to transform lives and urged the state to meet its obligations under section

29 while tackling persistent inequalities in public schooling.

He also called for active community involvement to accelerate real-world change.

The Trust's takeaway from Former Chief Justice Raymond Zondo's address was that we must continue to promote the view that home education is the way many families secure quality education for their children and that educational freedom contributes directly to quality education. The system must not impose barriers that undermine quality, dignity, or parental responsibility.

It was an honour to briefly meet Justice Zondo, who led the Commission of Inquiry into State Capture and Corruption.

From left to right: Karin van Oostrum (Pestalozzi Trust), Former Chief Justice Raymond Zondo, Christopher Cordeiro (Pestalozzi Trust)



Could Extra Lessons be a Solution for Academic Gaps in South Africa?

There is a concerning picture emerging regarding the number of students genuinely mastering STEM subjects in Matric. **Wynand van Heerden**, co-founder and owner of Edify, raises a critical question: Could extra lessons be the solution to bridging academic gaps?

The release of matric results each year in South Africa often brings a wave of celebration. While the overall pass rate can seem encouraging, a deeper dive into the statistics, particularly for STEM subjects, reveals a more concerning picture regarding the number of students truly mastering core subjects.

While the 2024 matric pass rate was around 87%, it's important to consider that a substantial percentage of students who started Grade 1 with that cohort in 2013 (49.75% or 606,950) did not matriculate.

Looking at core maths, of the students who began Grade 1 in that cohort, only 22,7% wrote the subject in matric, and a mere 14,2% of the original cohort passed it. Similar trends are seen in physical science, where 12,4% of the original Grade 1 cohort passed matric.

These figures suggest a systemic challenge. How do we ensure students not only pass but also understand critical subjects? Van Heerden believes these results "would have been far better if the majority of students had access to extra lessons".

The Broader Benefits of Supplemental Education

Extra lessons are often perceived as purely for students who are struggling. However, their benefits extend much further. "Certainly, extra lessons help those who're struggling, but they can help any student who wants to improve their marks - those who want to

Students need to be taught understanding through practical application of a subject, not just rote learning



go from a B to an A, for example, or even top achievers who want to improve their A in the 80s to a mark over 90%". The goal of quality supplemental education benefits everyone aiming to realise their full potential.

For homeschooling families, the concept of "extra lessons" might take different forms. These include specialised online tutors, co-op classes with a focus on specific subjects, or even a parent with expertise dedicating focused time. The underlying principle is providing targeted support where it's needed most.

Van Heerden argues that for true educational benefit, "students need to be taught understanding through practical application of a subject, not just rote learning". They also "need to be met and supported at whatever level

they are in each subject". This differentiated approach is central to effective learning.

Applying Effective Principles in a Homeschool Setting

While not every family can access formal extra lesson providers, the principles of effective supplemental education can be adapted for homeschooling:

Identify Specific Needs:

Regularly assess your child's understanding and pinpoint areas where they might need more focused attention. This could be specific concepts in maths, comprehension skills in language, or practical application in science.

Seek Understanding over

Rote Learning: Encourage your child to explain concepts in their own words. Use real-world examples and practical activities

to demonstrate the application of knowledge. For example, baking can teach fractions and chemistry, while building projects can illustrate physics principles.

Nurture Passion: Connect learning to your child's interests. If they love space, use that to teach astronomy and physics. If they enjoy stories, use literature to explore history and social studies.

Differentiated Approach:

Recognise that each child learns differently. What works for one may not work for another. Be flexible in your teaching methods and resources. The Department of Basic Education itself provides various resources and guidelines which can sometimes offer alternative ways to approach subjects, though their primary focus is on the national curriculum.

Leverage External Resources

Wisely: This could include high-quality online courses (many offer specialised instruction), educational documentaries, or even virtual tutors. Khan Academy, for instance, is a globally recognized free platform that offers extensive resources in maths and science.

The Challenge of Accessibility

Van Heerden acknowledges that extra lessons are currently only

available to the privileged few. This raises the real question: “How do we make them accessible to every South African child who needs them?”.

For homeschooling families managing their own educational budgets, this means seeking out creative and cost-effective solutions for supplemental support. This could involve:

- Forming learning co-ops with other homeschooling families

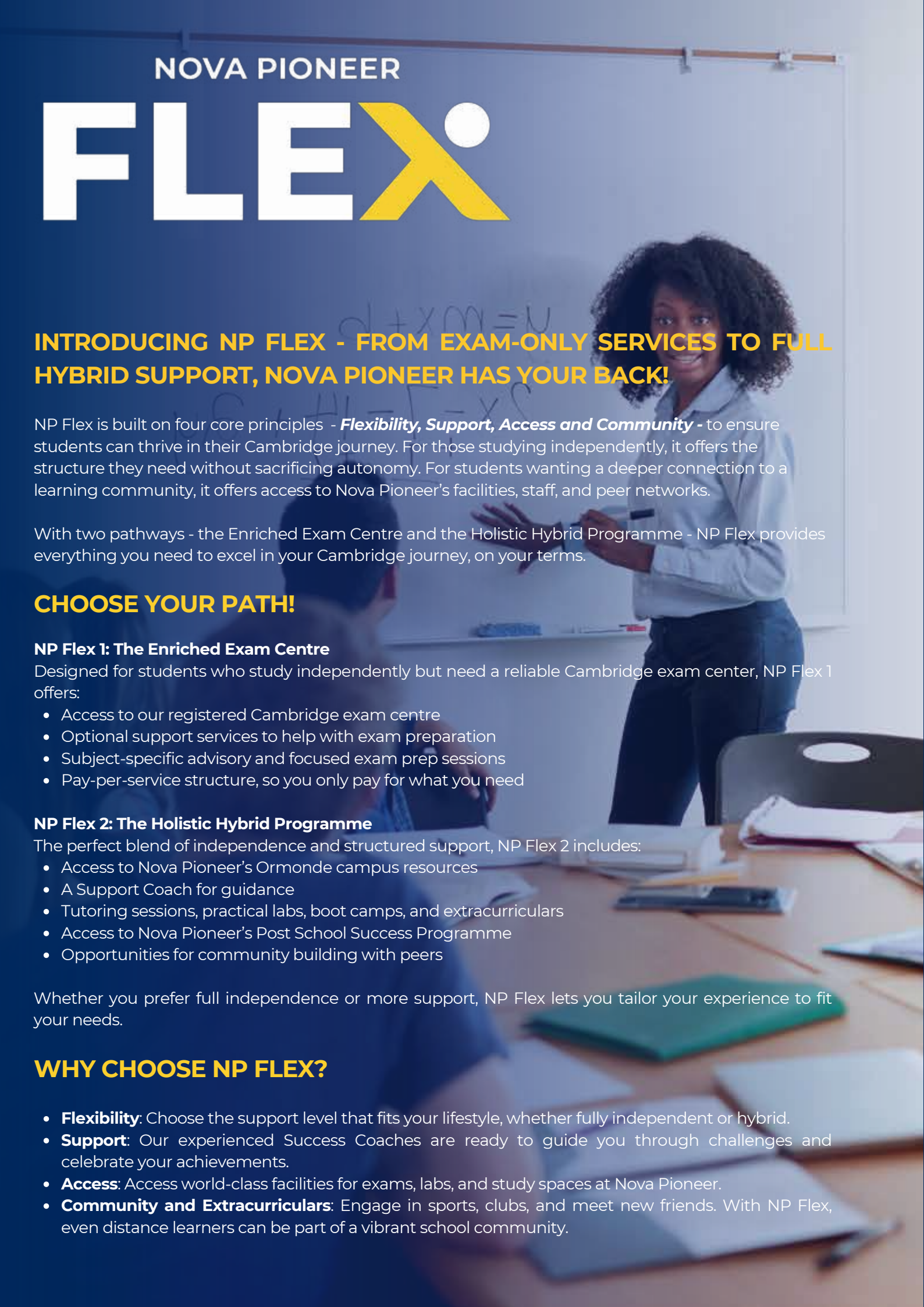
to share teaching strengths.

- Utilising free or low-cost online educational platforms.
- Engaging with community libraries and their resources.
- Seeking out volunteer tutors or mentors.

What are your thoughts on the role of extra lessons or supplemental support in your homeschooling journey?

Share your experiences and strategies with us on editor@digitalafrikan.com.

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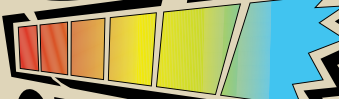
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The Ultimate Oxtail Recipe

A Perfect Weekend Cooking Project for Your Family

parenting 17

There is something truly special about the smell of freshly baked bread wafting through the home. Baking with your children is not just about the delicious results; it is a chance to connect, learn and create memories. This easy bread recipe for kids is the perfect starting point for your family's baking adventures. It is a fantastic hands-on activity for homeschooling, combining science, maths, and art in one tasty project.

The rich aroma of a slowly simmering stew is the essence of a comforting weekend at home. This fall-off-the-bone oxtail recipe is more than just dinner; it's a lesson in patience and a rewarding project for the whole family. Perfect for a chilly day, this dish transforms a humble cut of meat into a luxurious meal, making it one of the most cherished weekend family meals in South Africa.

Teaching children how to cook oxtail introduces them to the magic of slow cooking. It's a fantastic, low-pressure way to explain the science of cooking - how time and low heat break down tough connective tissues into rich gelatin, making the meat incredibly tender. This process, as explained by food science resources like Exploratorium, is a delicious science experiment. The result is a memorable meal that truly celebrates time spent together.

Teaching children how to cook oxtail introduces them to the magic of slow cooking and is a fantastic, low-pressure way to explain the science of cooking.

Share Your Weekend Traditions!

This dish is one of the most rewarding slow cooker recipes for families to create a tradition that lasts a lifetime. What special meals do you enjoy making on a slow weekend?

We would love to hear about your family's cooking adventures. Send yours to editor@digitalafrikan.com. Remember to share this recipe and **subscribe** to our weekly newsletter for more family-friendly ideas!

Ingredients for the Perfect Oxtail

This South African oxtail recipe creates a deep, flavourful sauce that is simply irresistible

- 4-5kg oxtail
- 3 large white onions, chopped
- 1 whole bulb of celery, chopped
- 6 medium carrots, chopped
- 3-4 small fennel bulbs, chopped
- 1L (4 cups) red wine
- 2L (8 cups) water
- 3 beef stock cubes
- 2 x 50g packets tomato paste
- 60ml (4 tbsp) Worcestershire sauce
- 3 packets oxtail instant soup powder
- Salt and pepper to taste

Step-by-Step Instructions

Preheat your oven to 180°C. Brown the oxtail in an oven tray for about 20 minutes until golden.

Child's Task: Supervise older children as they help chop the vegetables. Sauté the onion, celery, carrots, and fennel in a large pot until soft.

Add the roasted oxtail and tomato paste to the pot, mixing well.

Pour in the wine and simmer for 10 minutes. Add the stock cubes and water, bring to a

boil, then reduce to a low simmer.

Cook, covered, for 3-4 hours, until the meat is tender. This is a key step in any good oxtail recipe.

Once tender, remove the oxtail pieces and set them aside. Strain the sauce into a separate pot, discarding the vegetables.

Child's Task: Let your child help mix the oxtail soup powder with a little water to form a paste.

Add the soup mixture to the sauce and stir until it thickens. Pour the sauce over the oxtail.

Serve warm with creamy mashed potatoes or your favourite sides.

A Guide to Navigating Your Options After Matric

As CEO of Star Schools, **Vimala Ariyan** has seen many students face uncertainty after receiving their matric results. She believes that failing matric is not the end of the world and should not be a roadblock to success. There are various options for pupils to consider if they have failed or are not satisfied with their marks.

The release of matric results is a time of high anxiety for families across the nation. While some celebrate a successful end to their high school journey, others face disappointing matric results and uncertainty about the future.

This pressure can have serious consequences. The South African Depression and Anxiety Group (SADAG) reports that 9.5% of teenage deaths in South Africa are due to suicide, with disappointment over matric results identified as a potential trigger.

If your family is in this situation, the most important message is one of hope. “Failing matric isn’t the end of the world – don’t let it become a roadblock to your success,” says Vimala Ariyan, CEO of Star Schools.

The good news is that there are many alternative paths to a successful future. This guide explores the options after matric in South Africa, with special considerations for homeschooling families who may be navigating different curricula.

“

Failing matric isn’t the end of the world; don’t let it become a roadblock to your success. - Vimala Ariyan, CEO of Star Schools

Pathways for National Senior Certificate (NSC) Students

For homeschoolers who completed their matric through the National Senior Certificate (NSC), several well-established options are available.

1. Consider the Matric Rewrite Programme

Whether you have failed or are simply dissatisfied with your marks, you can rewrite your final exams. You must rewrite the same subjects you wrote previously; you cannot change them. Importantly, there is no limit to the number of times you can rewrite your matric. Many institutions, like Star Schools, offer programmes to support students through this process. "Many programmes... have been extremely successful over the years, with many pupils gaining successful entry into higher education institutions," Ariyan notes.

2. Upgrade Specific Subjects

If you did poorly in only one or two subjects that are preventing you from meeting minimum requirements for a desired course, you can choose to upgrade just those specific subjects at certain institutions.

3. Request a Remark or Re-check

If you believe there was an error in the marking of your exam, you can apply for a remark. This comes at a fee, but it could lead to a positive outcome that gets you into your institution of choice. Be aware of the strict deadline: you must apply within 21 days of the official release of results.

Options for Other Homeschooling Curricula

Many homeschooling matric options fall outside the NSC. Here's how to approach results for other common qualifications.

Cambridge Assessment International Education: If your child's AS or A-Level results are not what you hoped for, the Cambridge system allows for re-sits. You can register to retake specific exams in the next available exam session to improve your marks for university applications.

General Education Development (GED): The GED is a pass/fail qualification. However, if your child needs a higher score for a specific college or university application in South Africa or abroad, they can retake any of the four subject tests to improve their score.

Powerful Alternatives to a Traditional University Path

A university degree is not the only route to a successful career. There are many excellent alternatives to university in South Africa.

1. TVET Colleges

Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) colleges offer practical skills and knowledge for specific trades. These government-subsidised institutions provide qualifications in fields like engineering, hospitality, tourism, and information technology. You can find a list of public TVET colleges on the Department of Higher Education and Training website.

2. Skills Development Courses

Short courses are ideal for gaining job-ready skills quickly. They equip you with the knowledge to be functional in a work environment, start your own business, or become self-employed. Platforms like Coursera and local providers offer certified courses in high-demand fields such as digital marketing, web development, and project management.

3. Apprenticeships and Learnerships

These programmes combine paid, on-the-job training with theoretical learning. They are a fantastic way to gain practical experience, earn a qualification and get a foot in the door of a specific industry without incurring student debt.

What other options after matric in South Africa have you explored? Share your experiences and advice by emailing us on editor@digitalafrikan.com.





Why the American GED is the Smart Choice for SA Homeschoolers

The GED opens an exciting path for South African homeschoolers. It provides a reliable alternative to the traditional school-leaving certificate. With the right support, like that offered by Lernalot's GED Gateway, success is not only possible but also stress-free.

The homeschooling movement in South Africa continues to grow. More families are choosing this path for its flexibility, the chance to tailor education to a child's needs, and to spend more quality time together. As these learners reach the end of their schooling, a key question arises: what is the best Grade 12 equivalency? For many, the answer is the American GED.

The American GED is a credible alternative to the traditional National Senior Certificate (NSC) or Matric. It gives homeschooled learners a recognised qualification, respected both locally and abroad. It also offers a streamlined path to a high school equivalency credential, perfect

The GED Gateway was designed with the South African homeschooler in mind.

– **Shaun Swartz,**
Founder of Lernalot

for those who want to finish school faster and move on to further studies or work.

Understanding the GED's Structure

The GED is not a full high school curriculum. Instead, it is a series of four subject tests that assess a learner's foundational knowledge and critical thinking skills. This is a significant difference from the content-heavy South African CAPS curriculum.

The four subjects are:

- Reasoning Through Language Arts
- Mathematical Reasoning
- Science
- Social Studies

This structure allows students to focus on one subject at a time. The pressure of preparing for multiple exams at once is eliminated. Students can study and sit for one test, pass it, and then move on to the next.

Key Benefits of the GED for Homeschooling Families

For South African homeschooling parents, the GED offers practical benefits that align with the homeschool philosophy.

Flexibility and Pacing

Homeschooling is about learning at your own pace, on your own schedule. The GED supports this fully. There is no set academic calendar or a rigid timetable to follow. You decide when your child is ready to take each of the four tests. This is a game-changer for independent learners and those who might need more time on specific subjects.

Global Recognition

A GED credential opens doors internationally. It is accepted by nearly all universities in the United States and by many others in over 90 countries. This gives your child global opportunities for work and study. “The GED is not a ‘second-rate’ qualification—it’s a globally recognised stepping stone that empowers young people to take charge of their future,” notes a recent blog post by Go Prep, a South African GED preparation provider.

Accessibility and Support

Exams are available almost every day of the year at testing centres across South Africa. Results are often delivered within hours of completing the test. For learners with specific needs, accommodations like extra time or a scribe can be requested, helping them perform at their best.

Where Can a GED Take You in South Africa?

While the GED is not a direct entry into all public South African universities, it does open many doors. The South African Qualifications Authority (SAQA) recognises the GED as an NQF

Level 4 qualification, which is comparable to a South African National Senior Certificate (NSC) without university exemption.

Many private tertiary institutions in South Africa accept GED graduates. These include institutions like Boston City Campus & Business College and Stadio. For those who want to pursue a degree at a public university, a GED holder can often enrol in a one-year Higher Certificate first. After successfully completing the certificate, they can apply for a degree, often with a good chance of getting in. A Nedbank blog on alternative qualifications points out that technical and vocational colleges, in particular, provide valuable career paths for those who do not want to go to a traditional university.

Choosing the Right Preparation Path

Choosing the GED is a smart move. Preparing with the right support is even smarter. This is where a structured programme can make a significant difference.

Learnalot’s GED Gateway provides a clear, guided learning path. It ensures that students cover everything they need in the right order. The course includes high-quality video lessons, practice tests, and materials that mirror the actual exam format. The goal is to build confidence and readiness, test by test.

A standout feature of Learnalot’s course is the personalised, one-on-one AI tutoring. This support is available around the clock. If a student gets stuck on a maths question at midnight or needs help

with an essay at dawn, the AI tutor is there to assist. This is a game-changer for independent learners who need instant feedback and support.

Shaun Swartz, founder of Learnalot, believes in the power of this approach. “The GED Gateway was designed with the South African homeschooler in mind,” he says. “We saw a need for a solution that combines the flexibility of homeschooling with a structured, supported learning experience. Our AI tutor ensures no student is left behind, no matter their schedule.”

Beyond the Exam: A Smarter Way to Learn

The GED is more than just a test series. For South African homeschooling families, it is a way to gain a meaningful qualification without the stress and rigidity of the traditional school system. It offers a path to complete their schooling and prepares them for further study and work, both locally and globally.

As the number of homeschooling families continues to rise in South Africa, so does the demand for credible, flexible, and affordable education solutions. The GED, with the right preparation tools, is a practical option. It allows parents to provide a high-quality education that is tailored to their child’s needs and future goals.

If you are homeschooling or considering it, now is a good time to look at how the GED can support your child’s future.

Explore Learnalot’s GED Gateway to find out more about how to prepare for this qualification.



Homeschooling a Child with Autism in South Africa

A Story of Resilience

This is a story of one family's journey through childhood cancer and a subsequent autism diagnosis. It details the challenges faced within the traditional school system and provides a heartfelt and powerful picture of resilience and inspiration.

The parenting journey is rarely the one we plan for. For my family, this truth arrived with a force that changed everything. My son Leo's story is one of incredible challenges, but it is also a story of progress, growth, and the unique path we have forged.

For families considering homeschooling a child with autism, our experience may offer both comfort and practical insight. It shows that even when faced with immense obstacles, a tailored,

loving educational environment at home can make all the difference.

From Leukaemia to an Autism Diagnosis

Leo was a healthy, happy baby, meeting all his developmental milestones. At 15 months old, our world turned upside down when he was diagnosed with acute lymphoblastic leukaemia. We were rushed 400km from our home in Louis Trichardt to Unitas Hospital in Pretoria, where

Leo spent months undergoing treatment.

“
This journey, while
born of pain, has
shown us the depths of
our own resilience.”

Less than six months into his chemotherapy, Leo began having seizures and episodes where he would stop breathing. An MRI scan revealed he had developed neurotoxicity around his brain. It was a year later, when Leo was three, that a neurologist first used the words “autism spectrum disorder” (ASD). While one neurologist suggested he was born with it, another later confirmed my suspicion that it was caused by the neurotoxicity.

This dual diagnosis was a devastating blow. The term ASD is an umbrella diagnosis that covers conditions like autistic disorder and Asperger's syndrome. As the Centres for Disease Control and Prevention reports, ASD is estimated to affect about one in 54 children, with symptoms typically appearing between 18 months and three years of age.

The Challenge with Traditional Schooling

As Leo's health improved and he entered remission, he was able to attend a wonderful nursery school where he thrived. However, after the Covid-19 school closures, an obstacle arose when schools reopened. The Department of Education objected to Leo, then seven, being in a kindergarten class with toddlers.

Despite explaining his special needs and academic abilities, the department insisted we find an alternative. This experience is a common one for parents navigating a child with autism and school challenges, where a rigid

system fails to accommodate individual needs.

Special Needs Homeschooling

This obstacle forced us onto a path we now embrace. During school closures, I had already started working with Leo at home, using activities from his occupational therapist and worksheets from local teachers. Leo has always enjoyed schoolwork, and we discovered the beauty of learning at his own pace.

Our approach to homeschooling a child with special needs is built on patience and celebrating every small victory. There is no rush. If it takes him longer to master pencil-gripping because of low muscle tone, it does not bother us.

We know he will get there in his own time. Recently, he mastered cutting with scissors, a huge milestone for him. This focus on individual progress over standardised timelines is one of the greatest gifts of home education.

Adapting the Curriculum and Finding Support

Adapting the curriculum for autism is about understanding your child's unique strengths and challenges. For us, it means focusing on what Leo enjoys, like colouring, and building skills from there.

For South African parents, you are not alone. Organisations like Autism South Africa provide invaluable information and support networks. Connecting with other

families on a similar journey can provide emotional and practical support that makes a significant difference.

Our journey has been shaped by another medical challenge, as Leo was also diagnosed with Hirschsprung's disease earlier this year. Life remains unpredictable. The past six years have changed me from a relaxed mother into an over-protective one, but they have also filled me with immense pride.

“I'm really incredibly proud of Leo. I'm proud of all of us, of the progress we've made and how we've grown as individuals and as a family,” I often say. This journey, while born of pain, has shown us the depths of our own resilience.

*Are you
homeschooling a child
with special needs in
South Africa?*

What have been your biggest triumphs and challenges? Please share your story with us. Email editor@digitalafrikan.com.

If this story resonated with you, please share it with others who might need to hear it and don't forget to subscribe to our weekly newsletter for more inspiring stories and practical resources for your homeschooling journey.

A South African Parent's Guide to ADHD in Children

Receiving an ADHD diagnosis for your child can bring up many questions. This guide answers common queries about the types of ADHD, its effect on learning, and treatment options. It also provides practical, expert-approved strategies for supporting children with ADHD in a home environment.

When you suspect or receive a diagnosis of Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) for your child, it is natural to have a number of questions. Understanding ADHD in children is the first step towards providing the right support and creating an environment where your child can thrive. ADHD is not a character flaw or a sign of poor parenting; it is a neurodevelopmental condition that affects how the brain functions.

This guide, based on expert insights, will answer common questions about ADHD, from its different types to practical, everyday strategies you can use at home, making it especially useful for families homeschooling a child with ADHD.

What Is ADHD? Unpacking the Terminology

Many people still use the terms ADD and ADHD interchangeably.

In the past, Attention Deficit Disorder (ADD) was used to describe attention struggles without hyperactivity. However, this terminology has changed, and Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) is now the correct umbrella term. ADHD describes children and adults who face significant challenges with focus, impulsivity or hyperactivity.

The Three Types of ADHD

ADHD presents differently in each person. There are three main types, categorised by the most common symptoms.

ADHD, Predominantly Inattentive Presentation: A person with this type finds it difficult to pay attention and is easily distracted but does not show signs of hyperactivity. This is the type often referred to as ADD. In a homeschool setting, this child might drift off during lessons, struggle to follow multi-

step instructions, or frequently lose their school supplies.

ADHD, Predominantly Hyperactive/Impulsive Presentation:

This is the least common type. The person shows a constant need to move, fidgets, and acts impulsively without thinking. They do not typically have issues with inattention. This child

“
ADHD is not a character flaw or a sign of poor parenting; it is a neurodevelopmental condition that affects how the brain functions.”



might struggle to sit still for any length of time, interrupt frequently, or take physical risks.

ADHD, Combined Presentation:

As the most common type, this involves a mix of inattentive, hyperactive, and impulsive behaviours.

How ADHD Affects Learning

For most children with ADHD, processing information can be slower, which may mean learning takes longer. However, one of the biggest consequences is the negative labels (like “lazy” or “naughty”) that children are often given. These labels can have a damaging effect on a child’s self-esteem. One of the great benefits of homeschooling is the ability to



move beyond these labels and focus on the child’s strengths and needs.

What Causes ADHD? It’s More Than Just Attention

ADHD is a developmental impairment of the brain’s executive functions. Recent research suggests that challenges with concentration stem from specific cognitive weaknesses. A

fascinating study by the Gibson Institute of Cognitive Research found that among over 5,000

individuals with ADHD, sustained attention was only the fourth-weakest skill. The most significant deficits were in working memory, long-term memory, and processing speed. This helps explain why simply telling a child to “pay attention” is not effective.

Practical Strategies for Managing ADHD at Home

As a parent, you can implement several effective strategies to support your child. These are especially powerful in a homeschool environment where you control the structure of the day.

Create Structure and Routine:

A predictable daily routine helps a child with ADHD know what to expect. Stick to it as much as possible.

Break Down Tasks: Large projects can be overwhelming. Break them into smaller,

manageable steps to help your child feel a sense of accomplishment along the way.

Limit Distractions: When it is time for focused work, reduce distractions. This might mean a quiet workspace, no background TV, and putting away phones.

Encourage Exercise: Physical activity is a fantastic outlet. Encourage plenty of outside play and exercise to help manage energy levels.

Prioritise Sleep: Regulate sleep patterns with consistent bedtimes and by avoiding screen time for at least an hour before bed.

Use “Out-Loud Thinking”: Encourage your child to talk through their plans and how they will tackle a task. This helps develop crucial planning and organisational skills.

For further support, organisations like The Goldilocks and The Bear Foundation in South Africa offer resources and community for families navigating ADHD.

Does ADHD Go Away? A Lifelong Perspective

It was once believed that children outgrew ADHD in their teenage years because hyperactivity often lessens. While physical hyperactivity does tend to decrease, other symptoms like poor concentration and impulsivity can persist or even worsen in teenagers and adults. ADHD is a condition that usually continues into adulthood.

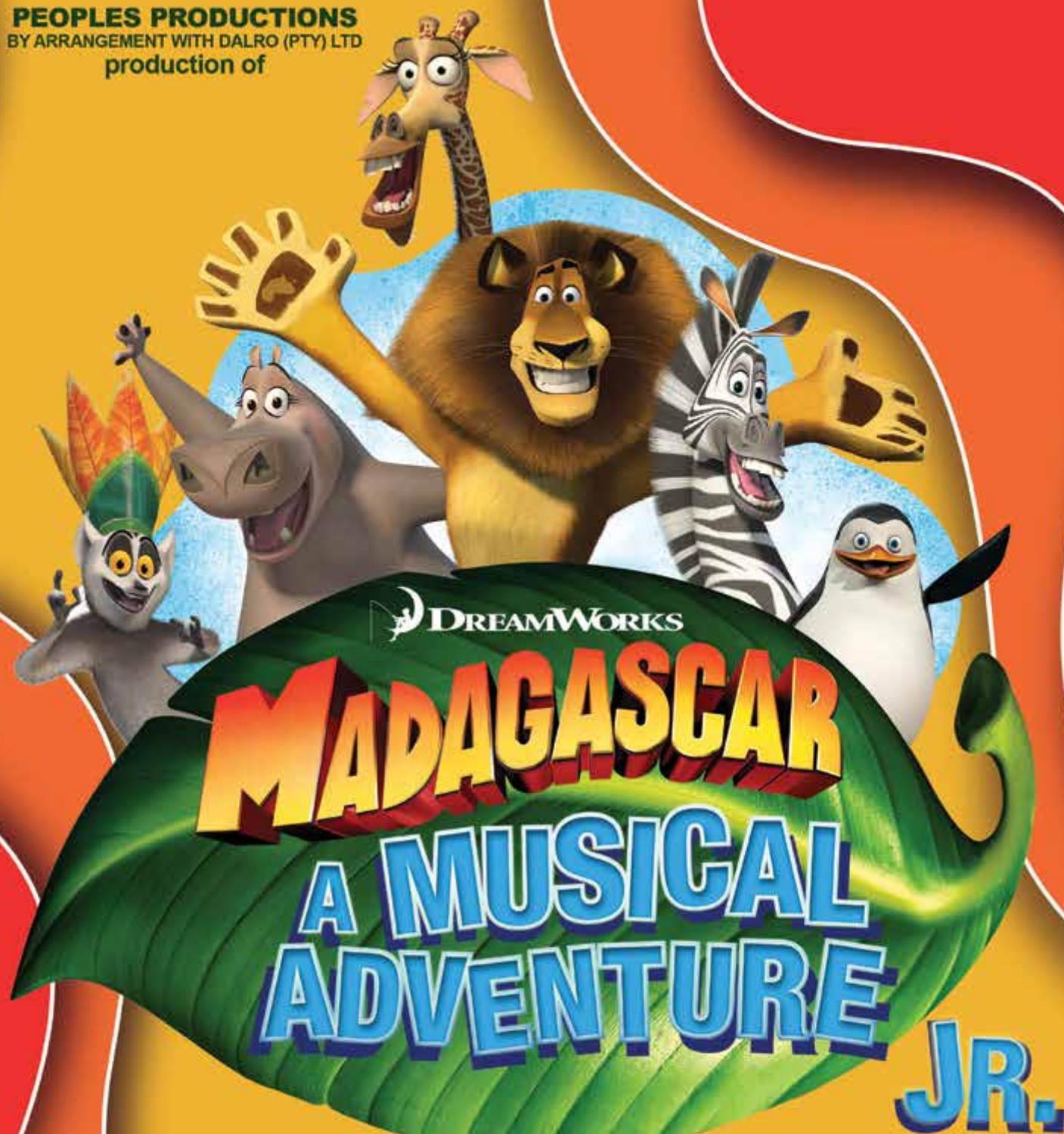
DO YOU HAVE EXPERIENCE HOMESCHOOLING A CHILD WITH ADHD?

What strategies have worked best for your family? Share your insights with us at editor@digitalafrikan.com.

If you found this guide helpful, please share it with other parents who might benefit from it and don't forget to subscribe to our weekly newsletter for more expert advice and resources for your homeschooling journey.



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9 Essential Tips for Effective Homeschool Organisation in South Africa

Author and homeschooling veteran **Shirley Erwee** explains that organising your homeschool life does not need to be a challenge. If you feel overwhelmed, these simple tips will help you create a system to keep your home education journey running smoothly and enjoy the time with your children.

Starting your homeschooling journey or looking for a fresh start can feel like a big task. Many parents find that establishing a solid system for homeschool organisation is the key to a smooth and enjoyable experience. A well-structured approach helps you and your children feel more in control and ready for learning.

These organisational ideas will help you enjoy your homeschooling journey and your time with your children more. From setting up your space to planning your curriculum, let's look at some practical steps to bring order to your homeschooling days.

1. Create a Designated Learning Space

Having a specific place for schoolwork helps children focus. This does not need to be an entire room; it can be a corner of the lounge, a desk in a bedroom, or a dedicated spot at the dining table.

The goal is to create a physical separation between “home time” and “school time”. This distinction makes it easier for a child to transition into a learning mindset.

Keep this area free from distractions like the television or high-traffic household areas. Ensure it has good lighting and all necessary supplies are within reach.

This simple step can significantly improve concentration and productivity.

2. Follow a Daily Schedule

Homeschooling offers wonderful flexibility, but children often do best with routine. A predictable structure helps them know what to expect each day. Creating a homeschool schedule

provides direction and helps prevent distractions from taking over. Your schedule does not need to be rigid. Consider a block schedule where you allocate time for core subjects in the morning

“
Homeschooling offers wonderful flexibility, but children often do best with routine. A predictable structure helps them know what to expect each day.”

and more creative activities in the afternoon. It is also wise to factor in unexpected events, like loadshedding, by having offline





activities ready. A basic routine provides a foundation you can adapt to as needed.

3. Use a Planner for a Clear Overview

A planner is one of the most effective tools for staying organised. Whether you prefer a digital calendar or a physical book, a planner helps you see the big picture. Use it to map out your term or year, noting important deadlines, tests, and projects.

According to the blog Homeschooling in SA, “Planning is not about creating a rigid, unchangeable schedule, but about creating a roadmap that gives you direction.” Sharing the planner with your child helps them take ownership of their work and stay focused on their goals. Keep it in a central, visible location for everyone to reference.

4. Set Learning Goals Together

One of the great benefits of homeschooling is tailoring education to your child’s needs. Start by outlining the key learning objectives based on your chosen curriculum and legal requirements. For guidance on legalities, the Pestalozzi Trust is an excellent resource for homeschooling families.

Once you have broad benchmarks, involve your child in setting specific, achievable goals. When a child has input in their learning plan, they are more likely to be engaged and motivated to achieve their learning outcomes.

5. Take Regular, Purposeful Breaks

Continuous work can lead to burnout for both you and your child. Schedule frequent breaks throughout the day. The length and frequency of breaks can depend on your child’s age. A younger child may need a short break every

15 minutes, while a teenager might work for a 40-minute block.

Encourage physical activity during these breaks. A short time outside to run, play, or simply walk around can improve blood flow and concentration. Research from institutions like

Harvard University consistently shows that physical activity supports cognitive function, making it a critical part of any daily routine.

6. Tackle Difficult Subjects First

It is a common strategy to handle the most challenging tasks in the morning when the mind is most alert. If your child finds subjects like Maths or Science difficult, schedule them for the morning. This approach, sometimes called “eating the frog,” ensures they use their peak energy on the work that requires the most mental

effort. Save easier or more enjoyable subjects for the afternoon.

7. Declutter at the End of Each Day

A tidy space promotes a clear mind. Make cleaning up the study area part of your child's end-of-day routine. Have them put away textbooks, binders, and other materials. This five-minute habit keeps the learning space neat, reduces clutter, and prepares it for a fresh start the next day.

8. Avoid Taking on Too Much

It is easy to fill your schedule with extracurricular activities, co-ops, and social events. However, overcommitting can lead to exhaustion for everyone. Be selective about your commitments. Choose activities that genuinely matter to your family and align with your educational goals. Periodically review your schedule to see if any adjustments are needed.

9. Remember the Curriculum Is a Tool

Finally, remember that your curriculum is there to serve you, not the other way around. Use it as a guide, not a strict rulebook you must follow precisely. The beauty of homeschooling is the freedom to adapt lesson plans to suit your child's interests and pace. You are in control of your homeschool.

What are your best
homeschool planning tips?

Share them on **editor@digitalafrikan.com**. For more helpful advice, be sure to subscribe to our weekly newsletter.





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